Chouette Rules

October 19, 2026

Starting

1. The agreed upon per-point stake is written on the score sheet.
2. Unless otherwise agreed by the players and written on the score sheet:
   - The Jacoby rule is in effect.
   - Beavers are allowed but not Raccoons and higher.
   - Extras are allowed as provided herein.
   - Partners are allowed as provided herein.
3. A designated person or player maintains the score sheet, an example of which is attached, and maintains the order of the rotation.
4. The players roll dice to determine the initial rotation. The first player in the rotation becomes the initial Box. The second player in the rotation becomes the initial Captain.
5. All the remaining players comprise the initial Crew and play on the Captain's side against the Box. There is a single game at the board, with the Box and the Captain moving the checkers, but each of the Crew and the Captain has his own independent doubling cube against the Box. Conversely, the Box uses those independent doubling cubes against each of the Crew and the Captain, and the games are scored as if they were independent games with the doubling cube multiplying the above-agreed stake, with gammons and backgammons counting according to Jacoby if in effect. All participants – Box, Captain, and each of the Crew – make independent cube decisions.
6. The score sheet must be updated and verified before each game begins.

Game Mechanics

1. The Captain moves the checkers on his behalf and on behalf of the Crew, and has final say over any differing opinions about the best checker play.
2. Each of the cubes operates as in a normal heads-up game of backgammon, with one exception: the Box must double the Captain on any initial double if the Captain's cube is still centered. In other words, he may not double a Crew member with a centered cube without also doubling the Captain if the Captain's cube is still centered.
3. Subject to the above constraint, the Box is free to independently double, redouble, take, or pass each cube independently of all of the others. He may double some but not others, he may take some cubes and drop some, etc.

Rotation

1. If the Captain loses, he goes to the bottom of the rotation and the next player in the rotation who is still in the game takes his seat as Acting Captain until the end of the game, or until he is cubed out, in which case the next person in the rotation who is still in the game becomes Acting Captain, etc.

2. If the Box loses to the Captain or fails to at least break even against his opponents as a whole that game, he loses the Box and goes to the bottom of the rotation at the completion of the game.

3. The order of the rotation does not change otherwise. In particular, winning or losing as Acting Captain does not change one's place in the rotation.

4. It is the order of the rotation at the start of a game that always determines who is Box (first in rotation) and who is Captain (second in rotation) and who is Crew (everybody else).

   As a consequence of the above rules:

   - If the Captain beats the Box, he will always be the Box next game.
   - If the Box wins against the Captain and at least breaks even, he will remain Box next game.
   - If the Captain loses and the Box fails to break even, both go to the bottom of the rotation (with the former Box last).

Consulting

1. A crew member may Consult with the Captain only if both his cube and the Captain's are in the game (not centered). In particular, before the Captain's cube is in the game, the Crew may not consult with the Captain (or each other), and their role is to observe the game and to make their own independent cube decisions. Nobody whose cube is not in the game can consult in any manner.

2. When Consultation between a Crew member and the Captain is permitted, such discussion may be requested by the Captain or offered by the Crew member.

3. These discussions must be about checker play, not cube decisions, so no such discussion can occur at all until after the Captain has rolled the dice and there are checkers to play.

4. When discussing available checker plays, it is permissible to discuss the merits of each, including how future possible cube action affects those plays.

Cube Order

1. Even when consulting is not allowed, a member of the Crew may ask the Captain to hold his roll so he can consider whether or not he will double.

2. Each of the Crew, and the Captain, is permitted to announce his decision to double, or to announce his decision not to double, or to take or drop an offered cube, in any order. However, each member of the Crew has a right to hear the final cube decision of every player on his side higher in the rotation than he is, before he makes his own final cube decision.
3. Neither Captain nor any Crew member may announce or indicate the reason for any cube decision he makes, only the decision itself.

Cube Proxy

1. There is a limited exception to the rule that the Box's opponents make independent cube decisions: if a Crew member needs to leave the chouette for a short time, he may ask another Crew member, or the Captain, to handle his cube while he is away. The Captain handles his cube if no other proxy was obtained. The proxy expires at the end of the game, or when the player returns. If the player has not returned by then, he is treated as having temporarily left the chouette, as described in the next section.
2. There is no good way to handle the Captain or the Box leaving in the middle of a game, except to wait, which obviously should be avoided if possible.

Entering & Leaving

1. A new player can join the chouette by agreement of the existing players. He enters the rotation at last position at the completion of the current game.
2. A player may temporarily leave the chouette, for example to play a tournament match. In such a case, the leaving player is taken out of the rotation and put to the side. When he re-enters, he enters the same as a new player, at the end of the rotation, but with his score maintained from when he left.
3. Any player may permanently leave a chouette after the completion of any game. He either cashes out his winnings from other players or pays other players to cash out, depending on whether his score is positive or negative. All players are expected to fully settle at the end of the chouette, or when they leave the chouette.

Partners

1. Partners are generally used only in a chouette of six or more players.
2. Before a game, the Box may invite the player next in the rotation after the Captain to be his Partner. He may decline without losing his place, in which case the next player in the rotation is invited, and so on. If everyone declines, the Box plays alone.
3. The Partner plays on the Box's side, against the Captain and the Crew, for that game only. He keeps his place in the rotation as though he were still Crew, so the rotation rules above apply unchanged: the order of the rotation at the start of each game decides who is Box and who is Captain, and the Box may invite a Partner again.

4. The Box moves the checkers and makes the decisions for the pair; the Partner does not handle the dice or checkers. The Box and Partner may discuss cube decisions at any time, but not specific rolls or checker plays. They may discuss checker play freely only after two cubes have been turned, whether taken or passed.

5. The pair share their points equally: their total result against all of their opponents is divided between them, with an odd point going to the Box when they win and being lost by the Box when they lose. The Box keeps the Box on the same terms as a lone Box, judged on the pair's combined result.

6. Private settlements between Box and Partner change only their own shares. They do not affect the rotation or who keeps the Box, except that a player left with no equity interest in the rest of the game may no longer be consulted.

Extras

1. When a player takes a cube from the Box, any player whose cube is out of the game, including any player who just dropped a cube from the Box, may offer his cube to the taker as an extra cube, at the value the taker just took. A player has only one cube to give, so he may not offer it again while it remains in play as an extra. If the taker accepts, he takes the extra cube at that value, against the player who offered it. The player pays the taker half that cube value on the score sheet, and plays on the Box's side for the remainder of the game. He may not advise the Box, but he makes his own cube decisions.

2. If the Box has no cubes left in play against any opponent while extras are still in play, the player closest to the top of the rotation whose extra is still in play takes the seat as a temporary Box and plays out the game. The temporary Box does not change the rotation.

3. Offering extras is always optional. Accepting extras is optional except in one specific situation: when the Box doubles everybody from the center and just one player wants to take, this lone taker must either accept all offered extras, or drop along with everybody else.

Chouette Score Sheet

Stake: ______

								✓	**Notes**

Chouette Score Sheet

Stake: ______

								✓	Notes

Using the chouette score sheet

Starting

Write the per-point stake at the top. The Jacoby rule applies unless waived. Write each player's name at the head of a column, in any order; column order has nothing to do with rotation order. See the separate Chouette Rules for how to set up and maintain the rotation during the chouette. Blank columns can accommodate newcomers.

Scoring a game

The Box's game against each opponent is scored separately according to that individual cube: the cube value finally held, or passed, times 1, 2 or 3 for a single, gammon or backgammon, as the Jacoby rule allows.

In each opponent's small box write what that opponent won (+) or lost (–), in points. In the Box's small box write the total of what he won (+) or lost (–). Then, in the large area of each cell, write the new total: the previous total plus the figure in the small box.

Check: Add the small-box figures across the row. They must sum to zero. Add the totals in the boxes across the row. They must sum to zero also. Check the box and start the next game.

Entering and leaving

A new player entering takes a blank column and starts at 0 on the row where he joins. Note his entry in the column at the right.

A player who steps away temporarily keeps his column and his total. For all the games he is away, record 0 in the small box and carry his total down.

A player who leaves for good cashes out. Record the amount he pays (+) or receives (–) in his small box, and record the amount each player pays him (+) or receives from him (–) in the appropriate column. Total up and Check as above: the rows sum to zero, and the cashed-out player has a zero total also. Note his exit in the column at the right.

Finishing

At the end of the chouette, each player cashes out as described above. The total of each player is now 0. Wait for the next chouette.

Worked example

Anne	Bob	Caleb	Daria	✓	Notes
+4 **4**	-2 **-2**	-1 **-1**	-1 **-1**	✓	*Start of chouette.*
-2 **2**	+1 **-1**	+2 **1**	-1 **-2**	✓	
0 **2**	+1 **0**	-1 **0**	0 **-2**	✓	*Bob is out.*
-1 **1**		-1 **-1**	+2 **0**	✓	
-1 **0**		+1 **0**	0 **0**	✓	*End of chouette.*

Rotation in effect at start of period. Leftmost is box.

Anne / Bob / Caleb / Daria

Anne / Caleb / Daria / Bob

Caleb / Daria / Bob / Anne

Caleb / Daria / Anne

Line 1. Anne, in the Box, beats Bob (Captain) with the cube at 2, and beats Caleb and Daria with the cube at 1. Her small box shows +4, and the others show –2, –1 and –1.

Line 2. Caleb is now Captain, Bob is Crew. Caleb wins with his cube at 2 and Bob with his at 1; Daria had already passed Anne's double, so Anne wins 1 from Daria. Anne's net is –2 –1 +1 = –2. Each row's small boxes sum to 0, and the totals do too.

Line 3. Bob leaves the chouette and pays 1 point to Caleb. His small box shows +1, bringing his total to 0; Caleb's shows –1, bringing his to 0. The others record 0 and carry their totals down.

Line 4. Caleb, as Captain, beat the Box in Line 2, so he is now the Box; Daria is Captain and Anne is Crew. Caleb doubles them both. Anne passes, so Caleb wins 1 from her. Daria takes and wins a single with the cube at 2, so Caleb loses 2 to her. His net is –2 +1 = –1. Bob's column is closed and left blank.

Line 5. Everybody cashes out. Caleb pays 1 point to Anne; Daria, at zero, neither pays nor receives. Every total is now 0.

Cube Extras

Chris	Todd	Pete	Steve	✓	Notes	*Rotation in effect at start of period. Leftmost is box.*
3	-2	7	-8	✓		
+2	-1		-1	✓	*drops*	Chris / Pete / Steve / Todd
	-1	+2	-1	✓	*extras*	Chris / Pete / Steve / Todd
+4 9	+4 0	-12 -3	+4 -6	✓	*end of game*	Chris / Pete / Steve / Todd
						Chris / Steve / Todd / Pete

Line 1. Prior games.

Line 2. Box Chris doubles all from center. Captain Pete is the lone taker. Record the drops now.

Line 3. Crew gives Extras. Record those payments now.

Line 4. Box & Captain play with one cube visible. Box gammons Captain. Record gammon for box, copy same value to each extra giver, extra taker makes up the balance.

Line 5. Steve is next up as Captain.

Partners

Chris	Todd	Pete	Steve	Jerry	Hana	✓	Notes	** marks this game's Partner.*
9	0	-3	-6	0	0	✓	*Hana is in.* *Jerry is in.*	Chris / Steve / Todd* / Pete / Jerry / Hana
+1	+1			-1	-1	✓		Chris / Steve / Todd* / Pete / Jerry / Hana
+1	+1		-2	0	0	✓		Chris / Steve / Todd* / Pete / Jerry / Hana
-1 10	-1 1	+2 -1	0 -8	0 -1	0 -1	✓		Chris / Steve / Todd* / Pete / Jerry / Hana
								Chris / Todd / Pete / Jerry / Hana / Steve

Line 1. Hana and Jerry join at the bottom. Box Chris invites Todd, next in line after Captain Steve, to be his Partner. Todd accepts.

Line 2. Box doubles everyone. Jerry and Hana pass. Steve and Pete take, so their boxes stay open. The partners split the two points.

Line 3. Box redoubles and Captain Steve drops, losing 2. Pete is Acting Captain.

Line 4. Pete wins a single with the cube at 2, so the partners lose 2 and split it. Together they are up 2 on the game, and they beat the Captain.

Line 5. Chris keeps the Box and Steve goes to the bottom. The partnership is over. Todd is now Captain, and Chris may invite Pete.